

Introduction

Examiners look at five different things in order to determine a candidate's score:

1. Pronunciation
 2. Grammar
 3. Vocabulary
 4. Fluency and Coherence
- Notice that Fluency and Coherence are grouped together although they are different things. Each of these four carries equal value. The examiner gives you a whole-number sub-score for each of these and then calculates the average of the four.
 - Both whole number and half band scores, such as 6.5 are given for the Speaking test.
 - No separate score is given for each of the three Parts of the test. When I was an examiner, I wrote the formula for calculating the final score for the Speaking test as follows:
$$\text{Final Score} = \frac{\text{Pronunciation} + \text{Grammar} + \text{Vocabulary} + \text{Fluency and Coherence}}{4}$$

- In China, about 50% of all candidates get a 5.0 or 5.5 for Speaking. In 2007, the average score for the Speaking test in China was 5.26 for Academic candidates and 5.0 for General Training candidates. (See [HERE](#) for the report.)

See here for the [IELTS Speaking band descriptors \(public version\)](#). This report will help you make a judgment on your description of what the examiner is looking for in order to manage the test, but it is not public Band level. Note that the Pronunciation criteria have been changed. You need to know what the new criteria are.

See here for the <http://ielts-ypds.htm>

See here for my more detailed description of the band descriptors available at www.yasienGLISHlab.net/DETAILED_BAND_SCORE_DESCRIPTIONS.htm

General descriptions of the band levels: http://ielts-AND_LEVELS.htm

See here for other, more general information: www.yasienGLISHlab.net/THE_BAND_DESCRIPTOR.htm

POINTS ON THIS PAGE

SUMMARY OF THE MAIN POINTS

Pronunciation

Understandable pronunciation is the main thing.

• Overall, clear and understandable

of the following features will determine the pronunciation

• Secondly, the correct use of intonation and stress at the word and sentence level.

understandable

1. basic word pronunciation

2. linked speech sounds;

words

3. correct and appropriate sentence stress (i.e., which word or words in a sentence are stressed more than others); and,

4. appropriate use of intonation (rising and falling) to emphasize meaning.

- Slightly inaccurate (= unclear) pronunciation is usually understandable if the correct words and grammar are used but slightly inaccurate pronunciation combined with other errors can result in language that is not understandable at all.
- American pronunciation is acceptable.

Grammar

- Basic grammar, especially the verb tenses. Know how to make the tenses and use them correctly.

- Complex sentences: Don't just use simple sentences all the time. Instead, often use sentences composed of parts that are joined together with conjunctions and other linking words. (This is a "must" for a Band 6 or above in this sub-score.)
- Complex structures: Show that you have some knowledge of higher level grammar.

Vocabulary

- Show a wide range of vocabulary.
- Use words suitably – don't try to impress with 'impressive' words you are not sure of.
- Make sure you correctly pronounce words – don't just learn the written form of new words.

Fluency

- Speed – push yourself to speak a little faster but only if your pronunciation is good.
- Continuity – avoid unnaturally long pauses especially in Part 2.
- Smoothness – use linked pronunciation and use contractions.

Coherence

- Expand your answers with a suitable amount of relevant extra information (detail).
- Use connectives to link sentences especially when expressing more complex ideas. (This is a "must" for a Band 6 or above in this sub-score.)
- Answer questions directly.
- Add extra relevant details in suitable amounts after **first** answering the key point of the question.
- Link your answers to the questions by using **the same** verb tense.
- Try to ensure that your answers to questions are suitable for the **real** meaning of the questions.
- Show knowledge of the 'short form' of answer for 'Yes/No' questions.

1. Pronunciation

2. Grammar

- For grammar, examiners first notice if candidates can make sentences using simple grammar correctly. The frequency of basic errors is what examiners first notice. The majority of these errors involve verbs, especially verb tenses. You should especially t

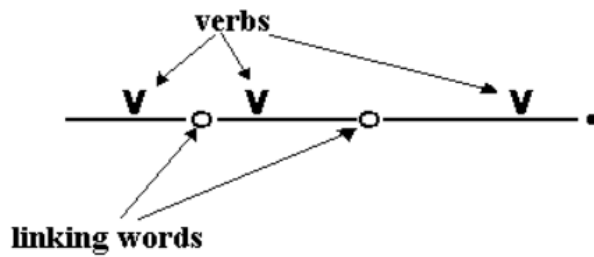
is not just a question of forming verb tenses (since the same verb tense is the answer). It is also a question of choosing the correct verb tense (since the same verb tense can be used in different contexts). It is also a question of choosing the correct verb tense (since the same verb tense can be used in different contexts). It is also a question of choosing the correct verb tense (since the same verb tense can be used in different contexts).

all number of errors but most of these are made when attempting to speak the more complex grammatical structures and these errors are not so bad that the listener misunderstands the speaker's meaning. On the other hand, a Band 3 candidate makes frequent grammatical errors (in almost every sentence) at the most basic level.

how often and how well the candidate can
ence is a sentence that has two or more parts,
words such as ‘*and*’, ‘*but*’, ‘*because*’,

- The examiner also especially looks to see how well you can make complex sentences. (A complex sentence is one containing each containing a verb, that are joined by a conjunction.)

A Complex Sentence



- A Band 4 candidate rarely attempts a complex sentence.

A Band 5 candidate tries to make only a few complex sentences, usually just using 'and' or 'but' as conjunctions. When they try to use more difficult joining words or phrases, they often make mistakes.

A Band 6 can make complex sentences with a limited range of joining words and phrases but there are still several, but not so serious errors.

A Band 7 can make a wide range of complex sentences with only a few errors.

And a Band 8 makes a wide range of complex sentences with almost no errors.

- Examiners also look at the candidate's grammatical range, that is, whether the candidate can accurately use the more difficult grammar, or complex structures such as 过去完成式 (the past perfect tense), 被动语态 (the passive voice), 情态动词的完成时 (perfect modals), 非真实条件句 (conditional sentences or 'if...would' sentences), and 间接引语 (reported speech). ~~As with basic verb tenses, the issue here is not just the correct construction of the grammatical structure but the appropriate usage of it.~~

A Band 8 candidate can effortlessly use these and similar grammatical structures with very few or no errors.

A Band 7 can use these but makes a few errors.

A Band 6 tries to use some of these but makes several errors but errors that do not usually impede communication. (The key point here is to try and to be correct **most** of the time but not necessarily correct every time. If you never attempt more complex grammatical structures because you are afraid of making any mistake, it will give you fewer points than if you at least showed the examiner that you know about these structures.)

A Band 5 cannot use (or is afraid to attempt to use) many of these higher-level grammatical forms. If a Band 5 candidate does attempt a more complex grammatical structure, he or she makes errors most of the time and sometimes attempts to remake sentences, trying to get the grammar correct.

- Most candidates in China get a 4 or 5 for grammar. It seems that the majority of students in China don't include much grammar study in their IELTS preparation. This is a serious mistake – it is very difficult to get a 6 for Speaking (and Writing) or an overall 6.5 or above in the whole IELTS test if you don't do much grammar study or at the very least, a review of your grammar. You need to not only know how to make the different verb tenses and the more complex grammar structures, you also need to understand the correct usage of the different grammatical structures. And you need to know it well enough to produce it quite quickly in natural speech.

3. Vocabulary

Most candidates in China get a 5 or a 6 for vocabulary.

Examiners look at several aspects of vocabulary:

- the range and variety of vocabulary, (i.e., how well the candidate can use words from the simple, everyday level up to the 'expert' level when talking about different topics; how much the candidate can display an accurate and appropriate usage of idiomatic expressions; and how much the candidate speaks a variety of words which express the same idea, rather than repeating the same word several times.)
- the suitability, or appropriacy of the words that are used, and the accuracy of meaning that is expressed by the words used. Some candidates try to impress the examiner by using so-called 'big' or 'impressive' words but they use these words inappropriately or

...the reason is that the words but ones that you know are suitable and correct. The reason is that communication is the number one goal – if you use words inappropriately or incorrectly, then the examiner might have no real idea of your meaning. On the other hand, you will get points if you use impressive vocabulary appropriately and so how that you know the exact meaning of these words.

...the candidate's ability to talk about unfamiliar topics:

sions;

- the candidate's ability to use idiomatic expres-

4. Fluency and Coherence

- Fluency and Coherence are two different things but are grouped together because neither fluency nor coherence alone is considered as important as pronunciation, grammar or vocabulary. Fluency and coherence are both concerned with "the flow of language" – fluency concerns the physical flow of language while coherence concerns

fluency and coherence to get a particular
he examiner thinks you are a Band 7 for
will only get a sub-grade of Band 5 for
re.

- You need to satisfy the requirements for **both** to get a Band 7 score for this combined item. For example, if you get a Band 7 for Fluency but only a Band 5 for Coherence, you will only get the combined 'Fluency and Coherence' sub-score of Band 5.

Fluency

continuity, speed and smoothness

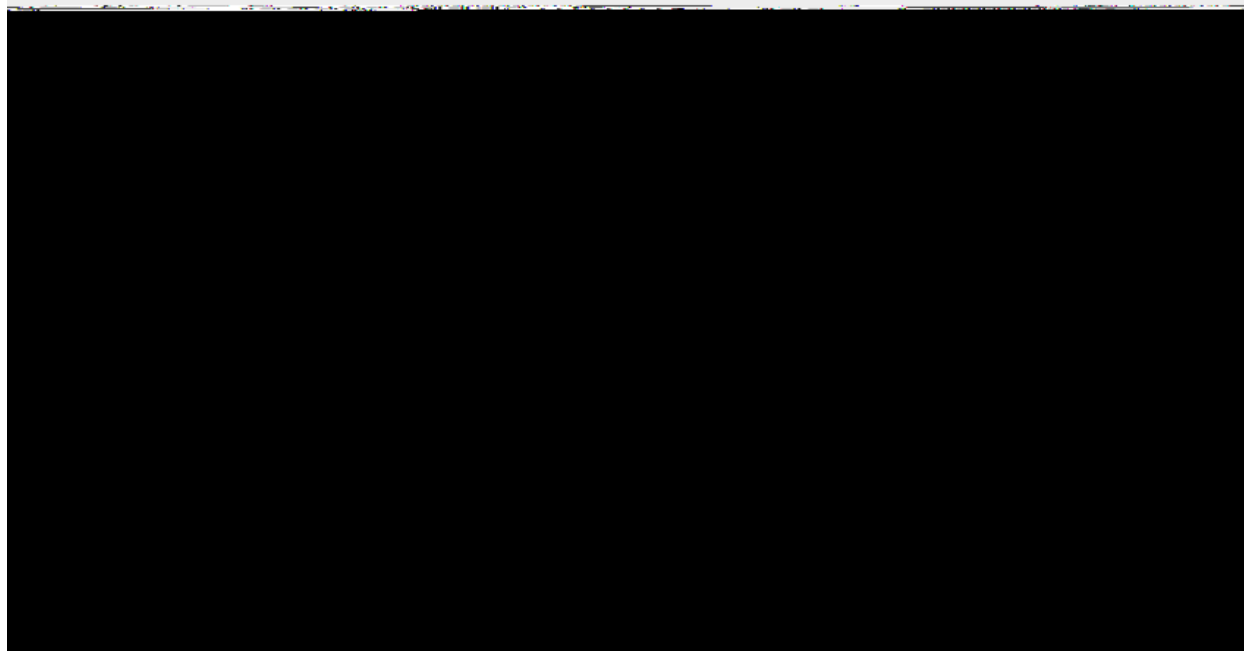
For fluency, examiners notice three related things: co

continuity

- This refers to your ability to just 'keep talking' without too many unnatural pauses

test. You will get a better score this way.

- Some candidates break the continuity of their speech by correcting themselves too much. If a candidate corrects himself or herself too frequently, this could result in a loss of continuity. Therefore, you should not self-correct more than 2 or 3 times in the whole test and only do it if you think you made a major mistake that could cause confusion in the listener or if you think the mistake just 'sounds terrible'. Furthermore



Speed

- If your speech is unnaturally slow, you will lose point for fluency. In the test, if you know that your pronunciation is fairly clear and accurate, you should push yourself to speak **a little** faster than you would in a normal, non-test conversation.
- But if you know that your pronunciation is not so clear or accurate, **DON'T** push yourself to speak faster because that could cause the examiner to not understand your pronunciation at all! You will lose big points if the examiner cannot understand you at

all.

st. This is a mistake, I
they should speak slowly.
lowly, but only slowly

- Some teachers tell (all) students NOT to speak fast in the test. I don't believe, because sometimes **all** the students then think that they should speak slowly. Only those students with poor pronunciation should speak slowly.

clear will lose a little on the Fluency sub-scale but that is far better than being totally incomprehensible in the pronunciation sub-score.

Smoothness

et to speak. If you can use the two methods mentioned, it will be easier to speak at a natural speed. Two of the main ways to "smooth" your speech, it is easier are a) to link your words and, b) to use contractions.

a) Linked Speech

most words are not spoken as single words but are linked with the words. If you try to say each word individually, it will not sound "smooth" and it will almost certainly be too slow. One of the main examples of linking is the pronunciation of words that begin with a vowel sound. For example, the sentence, "I'm an accountant" has two words that begin with a vowel, "an" and "accountant" and the sentence is spoken as:



b) Contracted Speech (缩写式)

we use the contracted forms of some verb constructions very often. Examples of contractions are: "I'm" = "I am"; "I'll" = "I will". We use the full forms to show emphasis or when we want to speak especially clearly for some reason, such as when stating a name.

fastest way to speak and they are spoken in a smoother way than the full forms. Therefore, using contractions improves your fluency.

In natural spoken English, we often, or even most of the time, use contracted forms. For example, "I'll" = "I will"; and, "I'd" = "I would". We use the full forms to show emphasis or when we want to speak especially clearly for some reason, such as when stating a name.

The contracted forms are a faster way to speak and they are spoken in a smoother way than the full forms. Therefore, using contractions improves your fluency.

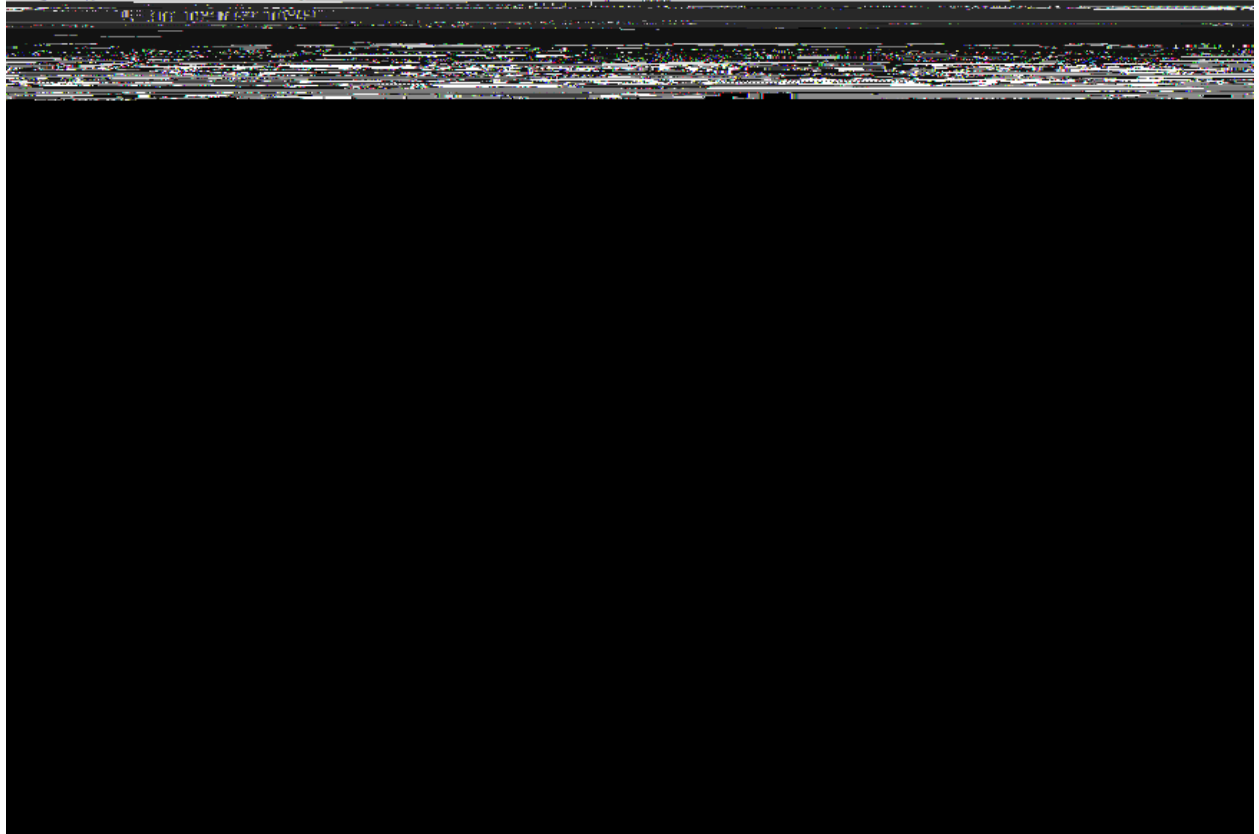
In the IELTS Speaking test, you should try to use the contracted forms at least 50% of the time.

ideas are stated in a logical order. For example, if you are explaining something that has several steps, you first talk about the first step and continue on to the last step. In this



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- Using good coherence is especially important when a speaker speaks for a long time, as in Part 2 or when a speaker is explaining something rather complex or abstract, as in the



- Show the examiner that you can use the '[short form](#)' of answers to 'Yes/No' questions. These short forms are clearer and more *emphatic* than simply saying, "Yes" or "No" and are, as a result, more coherent.

- Although you should answer questions directly, that does not always mean that you

- Showing your coherence skills becomes more important as you progress through the test from Part 1 to Part 3. In Part 2, where you describe something in detail for about 1.5